The revelation that the NSA had eavesdropped on German chancellor Angela Merkel's iPhone raised the following question: Is the information that can be obtained by spying on friends more important than the damage caused if and when such actions are discovered?

In this regard President Barack Obama said, "Could technology interfere with our common sense?" On the face of it, it seems that this is a condemnation of the manner in which the NSA used technology. But a more in-depth analysis of his statement suggests that his approach to the issue was not one-sided and that he was aware of the dilemmas involved.

Snowden and those behind WikiLeaks claim that their disclosure of the practice of wiretapping and other methods used by the NSA and similar agencies contributed to the transparency and values of an open society. These values—liberty, transparency, civil rights, equality before the law, privacy, and more—make up the foundation of societies in Western democracies. But the question is, Will total transparency contribute to a better world? Is maintaining the security of the state not a value? Is protecting the lives of agents/spies not a value? Is the struggle against global terrorism not a value?

Western society has succeeded in creating mechanisms whose function is to protect the citizen from abuses of power or arbitrary rule, and these mechanisms must be exercised when necessary. However, full transparency will not contribute to a better world; rather, it will lead to anarchy.

Among the thinkers who examine these kinds of "cyber dilemmas" are those who interpret the phenomenon as a new type of colonialism. They refer to cyber capabilities as a new type of weapon designed to enable the "cyber superpowers" to expand their influence over, and perhaps even control, "weaker" countries, not by causing destruction but by paralyzing and disabling their infrastructures.

On the NSA's Capabilities as Published by Snowden

For years, the NSA's policy was that surveillance and hacking, anywhere around the world and for any purpose that it saw as serving the interests of the United States, was legitimate.

The NSA is an organization of thirty-five thousand employees with an annual budget of $11 billion. It dwarfs all of its counterparts in the world, except perhaps those in Russia and China.